

Topic 4.2 - Pakistan's National Professional Standards for Teachers

A real classroom situation

Sadia has been teaching Class 5 for two years. Her head tells her that her appraisal this year will be "against the standards", hands her a photocopied form, and moves on.

The form has boxes. Some of them say things like "demonstrates knowledge of learners' development" and "creates a supportive learning environment". Sadia reads them and has no idea what she is supposed to write, or what evidence anyone expects, or whether her own honest answer of "some days" is permitted.

This is what happens when a teacher meets a standards framework without ever having been taught how one is built. The form is not the problem. Not knowing the architecture behind it is.

Explanation

The structure of Pakistan's National Professional Standards for Teachers

The National Professional Standards for Teachers were issued by the Ministry of Education, Government of Pakistan, in 2009, developed with support from UNESCO and USAID. They are the framework against which teacher education programmes in Pakistan are accredited, which is why they govern your own degree as well as your later practice.

The architecture has three levels, and the figure above shows them nested.

The standard. A broad area of professional competence. There are ten.

The three internal parts. Each standard is divided the same way, and this is the piece Sadia was never told:

- *Knowledge and understanding* - what the teacher knows about that area.
- *Dispositions* - the attitudes and values the teacher holds in relation to it.
- *Performance and skills* - what the teacher can actually do.

This three-part division is the most useful single thing in the framework, because it separates three genuinely different kinds of shortfall. A teacher may know the theory of assessment, believe in its importance, and still be unable to write a decent test item. Those are three different problems with three different remedies, and a framework that only asked "is this teacher good at assessment?" would hide the distinction.

Indicators. Beneath the parts sit indicators: specific, observable statements of what meeting that part looks like in practice. Indicators are what an appraiser actually looks for and what a teacher actually collects evidence against.

The domains the standards cover

The ten standards cover the following areas:

1. Subject matter knowledge
2. Human growth and development
3. Knowledge of Islamic ethical values and social life skills
4. Instructional planning and strategies
5. Assessment
6. Learning environment
7. Effective communication and proficient use of information and communication technologies
8. Collaboration and partnership
9. Continuous professional development and code of conduct
10. Teaching of English as a second or foreign language

Read that list against the previous three units and the design becomes legible. Standard 9 contains Unit 2's code of conduct and Unit 6's continuing

development. Standard 6 is Unit 3's classroom climate. Standard 8 is Unit 3's relationships with colleagues and community. The framework is not a separate subject from the rest of this course; it is the course written in the form a system can act on.

Three observations about the list itself, which are the kind of thing you should notice about any framework.

It is a mixture of kinds. Some entries are knowledge areas (subject matter, human development), some are practices (planning, assessment), one is a values area, and one is subject-specific (English language teaching). That mixture is normal in national frameworks and it means the standards are not parallel: they cannot all be evidenced the same way.

It reflects a particular country at a particular time. The inclusion of English language teaching and of information technology tells you what Pakistan's education system judged itself to be short of in 2009.

The full text matters and is not here. This topic teaches the architecture. The standards themselves, with their indicators, are in the document, and you should read it. Per the citation policy of this course, the primary document is referenced rather than reproduced.

Indicators, and how a domain is evidenced in practice

An indicator is where a framework becomes usable or becomes theatre, so it repays attention.

A good indicator is **observable, specific to the standard, and achievable under real conditions**. Consider three attempts at an indicator for the learning-environment standard:

- *"Maintains a positive classroom climate."* Not observable. Two appraisers would disagree and neither could be shown wrong.
- *"Displays pupils' work on the classroom walls."* Observable and specific, and a poor indicator, because it can be satisfied in an afternoon by a teacher whose climate is hostile. It measures a proxy that is easier to produce than the thing itself.

- *"Pupils volunteer answers, including incorrect ones, without prompting."*
Observable, genuinely difficult to fake, and closely tied to what the standard is about.

The third is harder to assess and worth far more. This is the recurring trade-off in indicator design: the easier an indicator is to check, the more likely it is to measure a proxy.

Now trace one practice through the whole architecture, which is the skill this topic exists to build. Sadia notices that when she asks a question, the same four pupils answer.

- **Standard:** learning environment.
- **Part:** performance and skills, since she knows why it matters and cares about it; what she cannot yet do is change it.
- **Indicator:** pupils across the room, not only the front, contribute without prompting.
- **Evidence:** a seating map with contributions marked, which is precisely the Topic 3.4 practicum task.

That trace is what Sadia needed and did not have. With it, the photocopied form stops being a mystery: each box is a standard, what goes in it is evidence against an indicator, and "some days" becomes a defensible answer if you can say which days and what you are doing about it.

A misconception to name: *meeting the indicators is the goal.* It is not. The indicator is a sign of the thing, not the thing. A teacher who pursues indicators directly, by displaying work they did not value or recording contributions they engineered, has optimised the sign and abandoned what it signified. Unit 3's warning about measures that can be satisfied without teaching better is the same warning in a different place.

Activity: Writing an indicator

Work in pairs. Choose any three of the ten standards.

For each, write one indicator that meets all three tests: observable, specific to that standard, and achievable in an under-resourced government school. Then

write one deliberately bad indicator for the same standard that would be easy to satisfy without the underlying competence.

Exchange with another pair. Their task is to find a way to "pass" each of your good indicators without actually meeting the standard. If they succeed, the indicator needs work.

Allow 30 minutes. The attempt to game a peer's indicator is the part that teaches, because it is exactly what a system does to an indicator over time.

Check your understanding

1. Name the three internal parts into which each of Pakistan's standards is divided. (*Remember*)
2. Explain why separating knowledge, dispositions and performance is more useful than a single judgement about a standard. (*Understand*)
3. List five of the ten areas the standards cover. (*Remember*)
4. Trace one classroom practice of your own from standard, to part, to indicator, to evidence. (*Apply*)
5. Explain why an indicator that is easy to check is often a worse indicator, using an example. (*Analyze*)

Summary

Pakistan's National Professional Standards for Teachers, issued in 2009 by the Ministry of Education with UNESCO and USAID support, are the framework this country's teacher education is accredited against. They are built in three levels: ten standards, each divided into knowledge and understanding, dispositions, and performance and skills, with indicators beneath that state observably what meeting a part looks like.

The three-part division is the framework's most useful feature, because it separates knowing, valuing and being able to do, which are different shortfalls with different remedies. The ten standards mix knowledge areas, practices, a values area and a subject-specific area, so they cannot all be evidenced the same way, and the list reflects what Pakistan judged itself short of in 2009.

A good indicator is observable, specific and achievable under real conditions, and there is a standing trade-off: the easier an indicator is to check, the more likely it measures a proxy that can be produced without the competence it stands for.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can describe the three-level architecture of the standards.
- ☐ I can explain what separating knowledge, dispositions and performance buys.
- ☐ I can name most of the ten areas the standards cover.
- ☐ I can trace a practice from standard to indicator to evidence.
- ☐ I can judge whether an indicator is observable, specific and achievable, and spot one that measures a proxy.

Try this at your practicum school

Obtain a copy of the National Professional Standards for Teachers and read one standard in full, including its knowledge, dispositions and performance statements.

Then watch one lesson at your practicum school with only that standard in front of you. Record what you observed against its indicators, noting where you could not tell from observation alone and what else you would have needed.

Write half a page on what observation can and cannot establish about that standard. Most trainees discover that the dispositions part is nearly impossible to evidence by watching, which is a real limitation of appraisal by observation and prepares Topic 4.3.

Summative task

Write 400 to 450 words.

Sadia has a photocopied form and no idea what to write. Explain the architecture to her, and use her question-and-answer problem to show how it works.

Your answer must set out the three levels, trace her specific problem from standard to evidence, and address why her honest answer of "some days" is or is not an acceptable thing to record.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Accuracy of the architecture (Remember)	Standards, three internal parts, indicators, correctly related
Quality of the trace (Apply)	Follows her actual problem through all levels to a specific, collectable piece of evidence
Handling of "some days" (Analyze)	Distinguishes an honest partial answer from a failure, and explains what must accompany it to be professionally useful
Register	Written so a teacher who has never been taught this could follow it

Further reading

- Government of Pakistan, Ministry of Education (2009). *National Professional Standards for Teachers in Pakistan*. The primary document. Read at least one standard in full alongside this topic.
- UNESCO / International Task Force on Teachers (2019). *Global framework of professional teaching standards*.
<https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000372167>

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